

China consumer

EQUITY: CONSUMER RELATED

Retail sales momentum weakened further in May

China's total social retail reading recorded first y-y decline since COVID; no turnaround signal of the sector yet

Total retail sales continued its weakening trend in May

China's total social retail sales recorded a 0.6% y-y decline in May to CNY4.1tn, the first y-y decline of this consumption measure since the end of 2022 when the Chinese economy was just about to emerge from the COVID-19 lockdown, according to data from the National Bureau of Statistics (16 Jun); the 0.6% y-y decline also missed the Wind consensus of a mild 0.1% y-y increase. Total retail sales of merchandise by enterprises above designated size was the major drag to the total social retail sales reading in May, decreasing by 5.2% y-y. Although the deteriorated merchandise sales can be partially attributed to high-base effect and unfavourable weather conditions (higher temperature and more raining days in May 2026 that limited consumers' activities), we believe the disappointing consumption dataset in May also indicates a broadening softness of the consumption sector. Given: 1) an absence of meaningful consumption-related policy stimulation on the demand side; 2) limited wealth impact of property market recovery in select tier 1&2 cities; and 3) limited support to consumption by the AI-driven stock market, we believe consumption sentiment will remain sluggish in the near term.

Looking into major consumption categories:

- Catering services sales experienced growth of only 0.6% y-y in May, slowing down from the 2.2% y-y growth in April; merchandise retail sales, as aforementioned, saw a more significant deterioration with a 0.7% y-y decline in May, worsening from the 0.1% y-y drop in April (*Fig. 1*).
- Most categories within the merchandise sales delivered weakened sales momentum in May (*Fig. 2*), except beverages (sales up by 6.1% y-y in May, faster than the 3.6% y-y increase in April), garments/footwear (sales up by 3.8% y-y in May, largely unchanged from the 3.6% y-y growth in April), and office equipments (sales down by 1.5% y-y in May, narrowing from the 6.9% y-y decline in April).
- Sales of categories including home appliances (May sales down by 15.6% y-y, vs. -15.1% y-y in April) and building/decorating materials (May sales down by 13.6% y-y, vs. -13.8% y-y in April) remained deeply in negative territory with no turnaround signals yet.

Preferred names in consumer sector

In light of the further weakened retail momentum and the lack of policy-driven demand, we maintain our preference for companies that demonstrate clear development strategies, visible margin trends, and attractive valuations (especially after the recent sector-wise share price weakness). We continue to prefer ANTA (2020 HK, Buy) in the sportswear sector. We also like Laopu Gold (6181 HK, Buy) in the retail space, as we believe Laopu is able to maintain a relatively stable margin trend and improving operating leverage, especially if spot gold price can stabilize in a more accommodative geopolitical environment.

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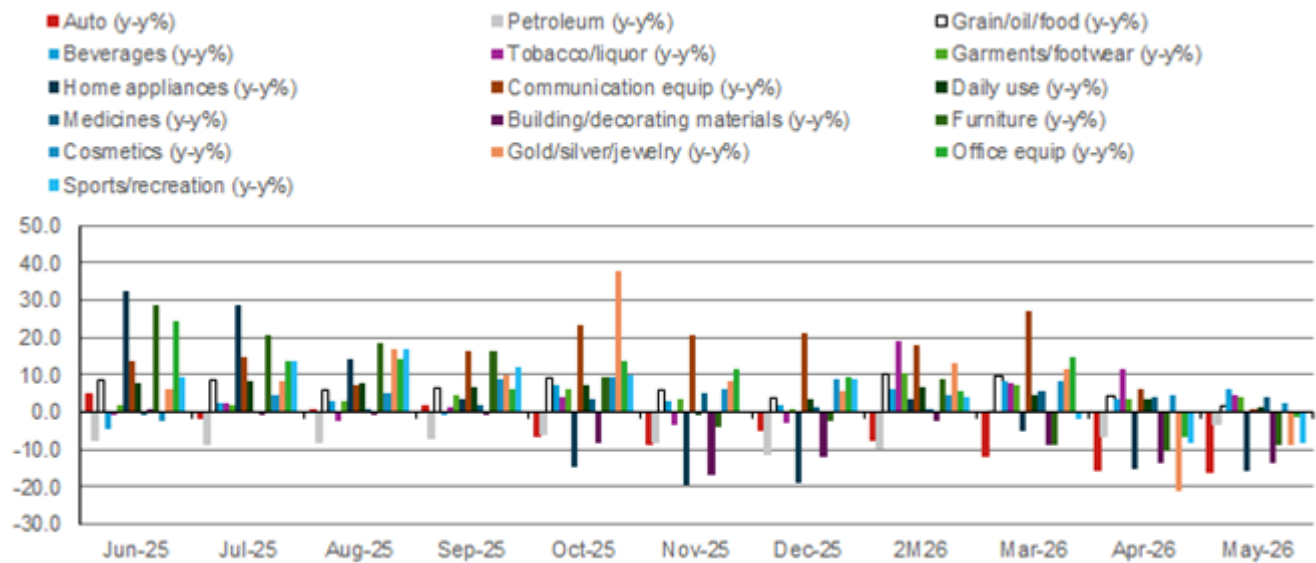
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Fig. 1: China – total social retail sales trend



Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 2: China – total social retail sales by category



Source: NBS, Nomura research

Appendix A-1

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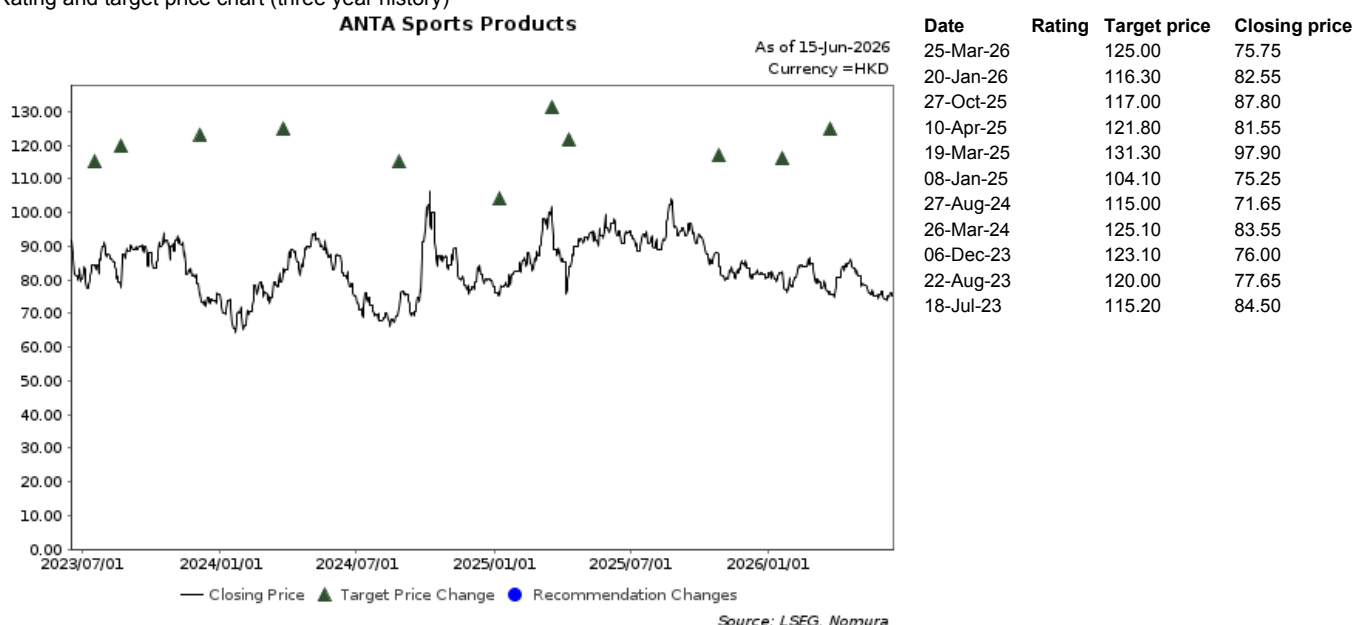
Issuer	Ticker	Price	Price date	Stock rating	Sector rating	Disclosures
ANTA Sports Products	2020 HK	HKD 75.30	15-Jun-2026	Buy	N/A	A10
Laopu Gold	6181 HK	HKD 487.40	15-Jun-2026	Buy	N/A	

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ANTA Sports Products (2020 HK)

HKD 75.30 (15-Jun-2026) Buy (Sector rating: N/A)

Rating and target price chart (three year history)



For explanation of ratings refer to the stock rating keys located after chart(s)

Valuation Methodology Our target price of HKD125 for ANTA is based on 25x F12M P/E, equivalent to its five-year average forward P/E. The benchmark index of ANTA is the Hang Seng Index.

Risks that may impede the achievement of the target price Downside risks to our Buy rating and target price for ANTA include: 1) intensifying competition from both domestic and global players; 2) slower-than-expected sales growth; and 3) weaker-than-expected macroeconomic dynamics.

Laopu Gold (6181 HK)

HKD 487.40 (15-Jun-2026) Buy (Sector rating: N/A)

Rating and target price chart (three year history)



For explanation of ratings refer to the stock rating keys located after chart(s)

Valuation Methodology Our target price of HKD1,114 is based on 22.5x FY26F P/E, consistent with Laopu's high sales and earnings growth trajectory. The benchmark index for the company is the Hang Seng Index.

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